



Are These the Most Dangerous School Runs in the World?

What is your daily school run like? Did you get to school by car, bus or train? For most of us, the journey to school or work is relatively simple and safe. However, for hundreds of thousands of children in remote areas around the world, the school run is no easy feat. Join me as we look at some of the most dangerous school runs in the world.

Scaling Mountains

For students in China's Pamir mountain region, the nearest school is 120 miles away. For years the journey to school would involve 50 miles on foot or by camel, scaling 1,000 foot cliffs, trekking on a narrow path cut into a cliff face, wading through four freezing rivers and zip lining 600 feet through the air! This couldn't happen every day but, four times a year after winter and summer breaks, teachers would escort kids on this epic two day, one night trek. Thankfully, a road was constructed in 2013 which made the route passable and the school run less deadly.

A Different Kind of School Bus!

Ever watched *The Magic School Bus*? For some children, the magic wouldn't be the only surprising thing about the show. During flooding in Indonesia, children travel to school in canoes, inflated tyres or homemade rafts. Similarly, canoeing is a popular choice for flooded areas in Kenya except with the added thrill of hippos and crocodiles! In South America, children in Argentina and Chile might travel to school by mule, while in China and Myanmar, camels and bulls are more useful.

Dangers of a Different Kind

Rebel armies in West and Sub-Saharan Africa pose a different kind of menace to school-aged children: kidnapping. Kidnapping children is one way to climb up the ranks of rebel armies and many boys are taken on their way to or from school. In 2015, hundreds of boys were captured in schools in South Sudan whilst preparing for their exams. They were then forced into the armies of the various factions fighting there.

The Universal Declaration of Human Rights, written in 1948, contains a specific clause about everyone on earth having the right to an education. This is because education (particularly that of girls) is an integral stepping-stone in developing nations' increasing prosperity. Although it is a non-legally binding instrument, it has huge political and moral gravitas and encourages countries all over the globe to adopt appropriate policies for their citizens.



War Zones

Since the war in Syria began in 2011, authorities believe there have been more than 4,200 schools damaged, destroyed or militarised and today there are 2.2 million children not in school. The tragic death toll of children stands at 12,000 and the conflict is still not over.

Frozen Wasteland

BBC's *Human Planet* series documented the astonishing school run taken across the Zaskar River in the Himalayas. Facing the perils of melting ice, avalanches and death from exposure and hypothermia, parents and children make an arduous trek 100km across a frozen river to their boarding school!

Next time you are bemoaning your long walk or delayed train, consider what you might have to endure had you been born in an alternative environment in another part of the world.